STREAM	NO. OF PARTICIPATING COLLEGES				
	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018
ARTS	172	162	131	121	102
SCIENCE	187	179	145	130	108
COMMERCE	213	202	167	151	121
MEDICAL	53	55	50	50	39
DENTAL SCIENCES	60	59	47	47	46
ENGINEERING	269	249	248	242	220
ARCHITECTURE	42	44	31	31	25
LAW	62	67	49	47	47
MASS COMMUNICATION	47	49	40	39	25
HOTEL MANAGEMENT	71	69	60	51	39
BBA	184	179	147	132	85
BCA	149	146	113	97	75
FASHION DESIGN	49	47	35	33	28
SOCIAL WORK	56	52	39	36	28
TOTAL	1,614	1,559	1,302	1,207	988

To arrive at an objective ranking, MDRA carefully attuned more than 112 performance indicators in each stream to enable a comprehensive and balanced comparison of colleges. These indicators were clubbed under five broad parameters: 'Intake Quality and Governance', 'Academic Excellence', 'Infrastructure and Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'. In addition, there was an attempt to gauge how colleges prepared to handle the pandemic.

To give more realistic, relevant and accurate information, MDRA evaluated colleges based on current year data. The tables also give parameter-wise scores for deeper insights on key aspects of decision-making by various stakeholders.

The ranking was done in multiple steps...

- An extensive desk review of MDRA's database and secondary research was conducted to prepare a list of colleges in each stream. Only those colleges offering full-time, in-classroom courses and that have had at least three batches pass out till 2021 were considered. Undergraduate courses were ranked in 12 streams, while postgraduate courses were evaluated for mass communication and social work.
- Experts with rich experience in their fields were consulted to frame the parameters and sub-parameters for various streams. Indicators critical to establishing the best colleges were meticulously determined and relative weights finalised. For fair comparison on year-on-year basis, weightages of parameters stayed unchanged from the past two years.
- Comprehensive objective questionnaires were designed for each of the 14 streams factoring in these performance indicators and were put up in the public domain—on the websites of INDIA TODAY and MDRA. MDRA directly contacted about 10,000 colleges fulfilling the eligibility criteria seeking objective data for verification. Attested hard and soft copies were sought and 1,614—55 more colleges than last year—eligible institutes submitted institutional data along with voluminous supporting documents within the stipulated deadline.
- On receipt of the objective data from participating colleges, MDRA verified the information. In case of insufficient/incorrect data, respective colleges were asked to provide complete, correct and updated information.
- Perceptual survey of these colleges was carried out among 1,781 well-informed respondents (544 senior faculty members, 306 recruiters/ professionals, 382 career accelerators and 549 final year students) across 27 cities, divided into four zones.

North: Delhi, Noida, Ghaziabad, Gurgaon, Faridabad, Lucknow, Kota, Amritsar, Chandigarh, Ludhiana and Roorkee
East: Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, Guwahati, Patna and Raipur
West: Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad, Indore, Panaji and Nagpur
South: Chennai, Bangalore, Hyderabad, Kochi and Coimbatore

- National and zonal rankings were taken from them in their respective field of experience and given 75 per cent and 25 per cent weightage respectively. Institutes were also rated on a 10-point rating scale on each of the five parameters.
- While computing objective scores, aggregate data was not used alone; data was normalised on the basis of the number of students for fair comparison. The total scores arrived from objective and perception survey were added in the ratio of 60:40—for 11 professional courses—while a ratio of 50:50 was taken for academic courses—arts, science and commerce—to get the final combined score.
- A large team of researchers, statisticians and analysts worked on this project. The MDRA core team, led by executive director Abhishek Agrawal, included project director Abnish Jha, assistant research manager Vaibhav Gupta, research executive Aditya Srivastava and executive EDP Manveer Singh.